Three Mistakes Families Make While Mom Is Still Doing Fine

Three habits nearly every family has, and the small fix for each.

When Mom is doing fine, nobody thinks to compare notes. Almost every family does these three things, for understandable reasons, and each one is easy to change.

1 Waiting until something happens to compare notes

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Everyone has a rough idea of how Mom's week goes, and nobody has said it out loud. The subject comes up at Thanksgiving, gets a nod, and is put away for another year.

WHY IT HAPPENS Nothing is wrong, so there's no occasion for it, and raising it can feel like going behind her back. AARP's planning guide says it's easy to put these conversations off because they can be difficult. It also says you may be surprised to find Mom has been meaning to have the talk too. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Use the quiet. Start with the question “What information should we organize while there is time?” and ask Mom to walk you through an ordinary week. The Family Caregiver Alliance tells siblings that if there's no emergency, they can allow some time to get everyone on the same page. You have that time. [2]

2 Assuming everyone in the family sees the same situation

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE You think of Mom as you see her at Sunday dinner. Your sister thinks of her as she is on the Thursday drive to appointments. Neither of you knows how the other would describe her week, because nobody has asked.

WHY IT HAPPENS Each of you sees different hours of the same week. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that parents often tell their kids different things about how they're doing, and that each person's outlook is bound to be different. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask it out loud: “Who knows Mom's daily routine?” Collect a few lines from each person, a text message will do, and put them side by side with a name beside each. Where two versions differ, you've found something to talk about. You haven't found someone to correct.

3 Leaving the everyday help invisible

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Ask the family who helps Mom and the answer is “nobody, really.” Then you start counting: your sister's Thursday drive, the neighbor who brings in the mail, the smoke detector battery somebody changes.

WHY IT HAPPENS Help that starts small never gets a name. Caregiving often creeps up on you, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, and siblings may assume one person has everything covered without recognizing what that person has taken on. It is also ordinary: about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. [3] [2] [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Answer the question “What help is already being provided?” on paper. List every helper, what they do and how often, and check with each of them that you've described their part fairly. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests that helpers make their own list too, for their own clarity and for family members who may not be aware of it. [3]

What the three fixes share

Say it out loud and write it down while the week is quiet: what Mom's week looks like, who helps, and who sees it differently.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how Mom is doing or whether anything should change, and it isn't a list of things your family has done wrong. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three habits and the small fix for each. The care interview gives those fixes somewhere to land: it asks about Mom's situation area by area, keeps the family's answers in one place, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The 80 percent figure is the Administration for Community Living's. The observations about siblings and about caregiving creeping up are the Family Caregiver Alliance's, and the line about putting the conversation off is AARP's. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Who Will Provide Your Care?

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